southern part of this island chain are the only two passages through which ships can pass safely. These sea lanes are critical for maritime trade flow between the Gulf of Aden and the Gulf of Hormuz in West Asia and the Strait of Malacca in Southeast Asia. The Indian Ocean is a highway for global trade and energy, and the Maldives is a gatekeeper at its centre. As matters stand, military and logistical assistance from India is crucial for Maldivian connectivity and control over the 1,100 islands spread over 90,000 sq. km.

Ever since it inaugurated its embassy in Male in 2011, China has been expanding its reach in the Maldives. In 2014, the Maldives joined the Maritime Silk Route (MSR) project, a branch of the Belt and Road Initiative, and received $16 million Chinese aid; in 2017, it inked a free trade agreement with Beijing. By 2018, Beijing had completed a major upgrade—including a new 3,400-metre runway—of the Maldives' main international airport and built a new bridge linking Male to the island of Hulhumale. However, by 2018, repayment of Chinese loans for development projects had saddled Male with nearly $1.5 billion in debt, a high figure for a nation with a GDP of less than $9 billion. China's former foreign minister Wang Yi visited Male in January 2022, when the two nations inked agreements to cement ongoing collaborations like housing projects and upgrades to the Velana International Airport. China also has an interest in obtaining basing facilities in the Maldives. In bilateral trade, China is fast catching up with India. Chinese exports to the Maldives in 2021 amounted to $395 million (Rs 3,290 crores); for India, the amount was $416 million (Rs 3,465 crores).

HUMANITARIAN ASSISTANCE

India has been the first port of call for the Maldives in times of crisis. On November 3, 1988, under Operation Cactus, the Indian army intervened to avert a coup attempt at the request of the then President, Abdul Gayoom. Moreover, India was the first country to respond to the Maldives' needs during the aftermath of the 2004 tsunami; it also provided 30,000 measles vaccines to prevent a national outbreak in 2020. In 2014, during the Yameen presidency, the Maldives faced a water crisis when a fire erupted in its only water plant. Indian aircraft and naval ships provided over 2,000 tonnes of water to Male. The Chinese response took weeks. During the Covid pandemic, Indian vaccines enabled the Maldives to vaccinate its tourism industry personnel, thus safeguarding its economy.



"Even if its uniformed personnel are withdrawn, India would still be happy to assist the Maldives in maintaining its security and maritime awareness capability"

Lt Gen. Anil Ahuja
Former deputy chief, Integrated Defence Staff

The Indian military has frequently come to the Maldives' aid by providing air connectivity between its islands for medical evacuation. "The statistics speak for themselves. The 470 medevac (medical evacuation) sorties from January 2019 until mid-2023 helped save 495 lives. The Dornier and helicopters have flown 430 surveillance sorties, including EEZ patrols to prevent illegal fishing and the narcotics trade," Rear Admiral Shrikhande says.

THE WAY FORWARD

Indian strategists believe that since Muizzu has started off with anti-India rhetoric, it will be difficult for him to publicly reverse his position. However, in actual governance, it will be foolhardy for him to ignore the role that India plays in the strategic calculus of the Maldives as a defence and strategic partner.

Pant says that in the short term, the symbolism of Indian troops leaving the Maldives—if that comes about—will be seen as a gain for China, though it is unclear what it will mean for the larger India-Maldives security relationship. Despite his anti-India posturing, Yameen had continued the defence engagement with New Delhi. "So, India's position in the Maldives, both economically and militarily, is very strong. In terms of what India means to the Maldives, China can never displace India," Pant adds. Vice Admiral Chawla agrees with Pant, but adds a cautionary note: he believes New Delhi needs to play it smart and not antagonise Muizzu, for his allowing another country to play a role could become a problem for India.

Lt Gen. Anil Ahuja, former deputy chief of Integrated Defence Staff (Policy Planning and Force Development), says that since the Maldives is by no means an Indian military forward base, the issue of moving Indian troops out seems more a political rather than a strategic narrative. "Even if the uniformed personnel are re-deployed, I presume India would still be happy to assist the Maldives in maintaining its security and maritime domain awareness capability by incorporating it in the Indian Ocean information architecture through information sharing or any other arrangement," Lt Gen. Ahuja says, while adding that there is no denying the Maldives' position in our immediate strategic neighbourhood.

When asked to comment on the India-Maldives ties in the light of Muizzu's election, some Maldivian politicians politely declined to come on record, stating that the political situation in the Maldives was very fragile still and that the leadership of both governments were trying to overcome their differences. ■